CDL Tanker Endorsement Questions and Answers

28 practice questions with answers and explanations, grouped by topic

Written from the Commercial Driver's License Manual (Version 07/20/2026 (form DMV 60A), AAMVA, Virginia DMV edition). Each answer names the manual section it comes from.

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https://cdl-testprep.com/cdl-practice-test/tank-vehicles/

How to use this PDF: answer the questions in Part 1 first, then check yourself with the answer key in Part 2.

Passing score on each CDL knowledge test: at least 80% correct (49 CFR 383.135).

These are our own practice questions, not the questions on the real test. CDL Test Prep is an independent study site and is not affiliated with any DMV, state agency or the FMCSA.

Part 1: Questions

Tank vehicle endorsement (4 questions)

1. What total (aggregate) rated capacity of the tanks is part of the rule for needing a tank endorsement on a Class A or B vehicle?

- **A.** 1,000 gallons or more
- **B.** 1,500 gallons or more
- **C.** 2,500 gallons or more
- **D.** 5,000 gallons or more

2. When does a Class C vehicle require a tank endorsement?

- **A.** Whenever it hauls any liquid in a tank
- **B.** Never; the endorsement is only for Class A and B
- **C.** Only when its tank holds over 5,000 gallons
- **D.** When it hauls hazardous liquids or gases in tanks of the rated sizes the rule covers

3. For a Class A or B vehicle, the tank endorsement rule covers tanks with an individual rated capacity of more than how many gallons?

- **A.** 50 gallons
- **B.** 100 gallons
- **C.** 119 gallons
- **D.** 500 gallons

4. If your vehicle needs a Class A or B CDL, does the liquid or gas you haul in a tank have to be a hazardous material for a tank endorsement to be required?

- **A.** Yes, only hazardous liquids or gases count
- **B.** No, it does not have to be a hazardous material
- **C.** Only if the cargo is a flammable liquid
- **D.** Only if the cargo is a gas under pressure

Inspecting tank vehicles (8 questions)

5. What should you do about the emergency equipment required for your tank vehicle?

- **A.** Leave it at the terminal unless the cargo is hazardous
- **B.** Find out what is required, and make sure you have it and it works
- **C.** Rely on the shipper to supply it at each loading site
- **D.** Check it only once a year at the annual inspection

6. What happens if you carry liquids or gases in a leaking tank?

- **A.** Nothing, as long as the leak is small and slow
- **B.** You get a warning and may finish the trip
- **C.** It is a crime; you will be cited and stopped from driving
- **D.** It is allowed if the cargo is not hazardous

7. On all tank vehicles, what is the most important item to check for during an inspection?

- **A.** Tire tread depth
- **B.** Mirror adjustment
- **C.** Placard condition
- **D.** Leaks

8. When checking the manhole covers on a tank vehicle, what should you make sure of?

- **A.** They are left slightly open for air
- **B.** They are painted to match the tank
- **C.** They have gaskets and close correctly
- **D.** They are removed before loading

9. Which of these should you never do with a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Drive it with open valves or manhole covers
- **B.** Drive it with its headlights on in daytime
- **C.** Drive it with the tank less than half full
- **D.** Drive it in the right lane on a highway

10. Because tank vehicles come in many types and sizes, where should you check to learn how to inspect your own tank vehicle?

- **A.** The cargo's shipping papers
- **B.** The vehicle's operator manual
- **C.** The tank's capacity plate
- **D.** The last driver's trip log

11. Which of these is listed as special purpose equipment you must make sure works if your tank vehicle has it?

- **A.** A backup camera
- **B.** A sleeper berth heater
- **C.** A CB radio
- **D.** Grounding and bonding cables

12. Which items must be in the correct position before you load, unload, or move a tank vehicle?

- **A.** The intake, discharge, and cut-off valves
- **B.** The mirrors and windshield wipers
- **C.** The fifth wheel locking jaws
- **D.** The trailer landing gear handles

Driving tank vehicles (9 questions)

13. What kind of liquid surge can still happen in a baffled tank?

- **A.** Side-to-side surge, which can cause a rollover
- **B.** None, because baffles stop all surge
- **C.** Only surge when the tank is completely full
- **D.** Only forward surge when the truck speeds up

14. When loading and unloading a tank that bulkheads divide into smaller tanks, what should you avoid?

- **A.** Loading more than one of the smaller tanks
- **B.** Leaving any of the smaller tanks empty
- **C.** Putting too much weight on the front or rear
- **D.** Unloading the front tank before the rear tank

15. Why may you often only partially fill a tank with a heavy liquid such as some acids?

- **A.** Heavy liquids do not expand when they warm
- **B.** Acids must have air above them to stay stable
- **C.** A full tank may exceed legal weight limits
- **D.** Heavy liquids surge more in a full tank

16. What does a high center of gravity do to a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Makes it steadier in curves
- **B.** Makes it easier to stop on wet roads
- **C.** Makes it top-heavy and easy to roll over
- **D.** Makes it less likely to skid on ice

17. Why do different liquids need different amounts of outage?

- **A.** They have different colors
- **B.** They expand by different amounts
- **C.** Some are hazardous and some are not
- **D.** They need different unloading hoses

18. What causes liquid surge in a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Movement of the liquid in partially filled tanks
- **B.** Pressure building up in completely full tanks
- **C.** Heat from the engine warming the cargo
- **D.** Worn springs in the trailer suspension

19. On a slippery surface such as ice, what can liquid surge do to a stopped tanker?

- **A.** Lift its front wheels off the road
- **B.** Shove it out into an intersection
- **C.** Lock up its trailer brakes
- **D.** Nothing, since the truck has stopped

20. When you stop a partially filled tanker and the surge wave hits the end of the tank, which way does it tend to push the truck?

- **A.** Opposite to the direction the wave is moving
- **B.** Straight down onto the rear axles
- **C.** Toward the side of the road
- **D.** In the direction the wave is moving

21. Un-baffled (smooth bore) tanks are usually used to haul what kind of cargo?

- **A.** Gasoline and diesel fuel
- **B.** Heavy acids
- **C.** Compressed gases
- **D.** Food products such as milk

Safe driving rules (7 questions)

22. What is the right way to take a curve in a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Keep a steady speed and brake in the middle of the curve
- **B.** Coast through the curve with the clutch pushed in
- **C.** Brake firmly all the way through the curve
- **D.** Slow down before the curve, then accelerate slightly through it

23. Compared with a full tank vehicle, how might an empty tank vehicle stop?

- **A.** It may take longer to stop
- **B.** It always stops in half the distance
- **C.** It stops in exactly the same distance
- **D.** It cannot skid when braking

24. If you must make a quick stop in a tank vehicle to avoid a crash, which braking method should you use?

- **A.** Controlled or stab braking
- **B.** Locking all wheels and holding them
- **C.** Pulling the parking brake only
- **D.** Pumping the trailer hand valve

25. How should you make turns and lane changes in a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Quickly, to spend less time in the turn
- **B.** With light braking through the whole move
- **C.** With a firm, sharp turn of the wheel
- **D.** Smoothly, without sudden moves

26. What may happen if you steer quickly while braking in a tank vehicle?

- **A.** The brakes may fade completely
- **B.** The vehicle may roll over
- **C.** The engine may stall
- **D.** The tank valves may open

27. On a tank trailer, what may happen if the drive wheels or trailer wheels begin to skid?

- **A.** The tank valves may open
- **B.** The liquid will stop surging
- **C.** The vehicle may jackknife
- **D.** The engine will shut down

28. What do wet roads do to the normal stopping distance of a tank vehicle?

- **A.** Leave it unchanged
- **B.** Double it
- **C.** Triple it
- **D.** Make it about 10 percent longer

Part 2: Answer key

Each answer has a short explanation in our own words and the CDL manual section it comes from. Reread that section for every question you missed.

Tank vehicle endorsement

1. **A. 1,000 gallons or more**
   Besides the size of each tank, the tanks together must be rated to hold at least 1,000 gallons.
   Manual section 8 Tank Vehicles

2. **D. When it hauls hazardous liquids or gases in tanks of the rated sizes the rule covers**
   For Class C vehicles, the endorsement applies when they carry hazardous materials as a liquid or gas in tanks of the sizes the rule describes.
   Manual section 8 Tank Vehicles

3. **C. 119 gallons**
   Each tank counts toward the endorsement rule when its own rated capacity is over 119 gallons.
   Manual section 8 Tank Vehicles

4. **B. No, it does not have to be a hazardous material**
   A tank endorsement can be needed even when the liquid or gas in the tank is not hazardous at all.
   Manual section 8 Tank Vehicles

Inspecting tank vehicles

5. **B. Find out what is required, and make sure you have it and it works**
   Learn which emergency items your vehicle must carry, then confirm each one is on board and in working order.
   Manual section 8.1.3 Special Equipment

6. **C. It is a crime; you will be cited and stopped from driving**
   Hauling cargo in a leaking tank is against the law, so you get a citation and are not allowed to keep driving.
   Manual section 8.1.1 Leaks

7. **D. Leaks**
   Checking for leaks comes first on every kind of tank vehicle, looking under and around the whole vehicle.
   Manual section 8.1.1 Leaks

8. **C. They have gaskets and close correctly**
   Each manhole cover needs its gasket in place and must shut and seal properly.
   Manual section 8.1.1 Leaks

9. **A. Drive it with open valves or manhole covers**
   Valves and manhole covers must all be closed before a tank vehicle moves.
   Manual section 8.1.2 Check Special Purpose Equipment

10. **B. The vehicle's operator manual**
    Inspection items differ between tank designs, so the operator manual for your vehicle tells you how to inspect it.
    Manual section 8.1 Inspecting Tank Vehicles

11. **D. Grounding and bonding cables**
    If a tank vehicle is equipped with grounding and bonding cables, checking that they work is part of the inspection.
    Manual section 8.1.2 Check Special Purpose Equipment

12. **A. The intake, discharge, and cut-off valves**
As part of the leak check, you confirm that each tank valve is set the right way before any loading, unloading, or driving.
Manual section 8.1.1 Leaks

Driving tank vehicles

13. **A. Side-to-side surge, which can cause a rollover**
Baffles help with front-to-back movement, but the liquid can still slosh sideways and tip the vehicle over.
Manual section 8.2.4 Baffled Tanks

14. **C. Putting too much weight on the front or rear**
Each compartment you fill or empty shifts the vehicle's weight, so keep the load balanced and do not overload either end.
Manual section 8.2.3 Bulkheads

15. **C. A full tank may exceed legal weight limits**
Dense liquids weigh so much that filling the tank could put the vehicle over the legal weight.
Manual section 8.2.7 How Much to Load?

16. **C. Makes it top-heavy and easy to roll over**
With much of the load's weight carried high above the road, the tanker is top-heavy and can tip over easily.
Manual section 8.2.1 High Center of Gravity

17. **B. They expand by different amounts**
Outage is room left for a liquid to expand, and since each liquid expands a different amount, each needs its own amount of space.
Manual section 8.2.6 Outage

18. **A. Movement of the liquid in partially filled tanks**
When a tank is only partly full, the liquid can move around inside it, and that movement is what surge is.
Manual section 8.2.2 Danger of Surge

19. **B. Shove it out into an intersection**
Even after the truck has stopped, the moving liquid can push it forward on ice, possibly into an intersection.
Manual section 8.2.2 Danger of Surge

20. **D. In the direction the wave is moving**
The moving liquid carries force, so when it reaches the tank wall it shoves the truck the same way the wave is traveling.
Manual section 8.2.2 Danger of Surge

21. **D. Food products such as milk**
Tanks that carry food such as milk are usually built without baffles, because sanitation rules ban baffles that make the inside hard to clean.
Manual section 8.2.5 Un-baffled Tanks

Safe driving rules

22. **D. Slow down before the curve, then accelerate slightly through it**
Do your slowing before you enter the curve, then add a little power while you go through it.
Manual section 8.3.3 Curves

23. **A. It may take longer to stop**
A lighter load does not always mean a shorter stop; an empty tanker can need more distance than a loaded one.
Manual section 8.3.4 Stopping Distance

24. **A. Controlled or stab braking**

For an emergency stop in a tanker, use controlled braking or stab braking; subsection 2.17.2 explains both methods.

Manual section 8.3.2 Controlling Surge

25. **D. Smoothly, without sudden moves**

A top-heavy tanker with moving liquid must be handled gently, and that includes turning and changing lanes.

Manual section 8.3.1 Drive Smoothly

26. **B. The vehicle may roll over**

Sharp steering during braking can tip a tanker over, so keep steering inputs gentle while you brake.

Manual section 8.3.2 Controlling Surge

27. **C. The vehicle may jackknife**

When drive or trailer wheels lose grip on a tank trailer, the rig can jackknife, so avoid oversteering, overaccelerating and overbraking.

Manual section 8.3.5 Skids

28. **B. Double it**

On wet pavement, plan on needing twice your usual distance to stop.

Manual section 8.3.4 Stopping Distance

Keep practicing online

This list with a hide-answers switch: https://cdl-testprep.com/cdl-practice-test/tank-vehicles/questions-and-answers/
Every CDL practice test: https://cdl-testprep.com/cdl-practice-test/